Do Mainstream Party Positions Cause Far-Right Support?*

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Abstract

Far-right parties have surged across Western democracies, and one explanation is that mainstream parties leave voters unrepresented by adopting positions more liberal than their electorates. We isolate this positional channel in an information-provision experiment with 5,040 Germans during the campaign preceding the 2025 federal election. Truthful, randomized signals shift beliefs about the center-right CDU's immigration position equally strongly across the electorate, leaving respondents' own attitudes and beliefs about other parties essentially unchanged. Political responses are concentrated among voters with restrictive immigration preferences. For these voters, a signal portraying the CDU as one unit more liberal raises AfD vote intention by 1.7 percentage points. Instrumental-variable estimates imply an increase of 3.5 percentage points per unit of perceived CDU position; an estimator that gives equal weight to voters who update toward the information yields 4.7 percentage points. Liberal and moderate voters show no comparable response. Felt representation changes in the two directions predicted by spatial voting: a more liberal perceived CDU position reduces representation among restrictive voters and increases it among liberal voters. The substitution extends beyond stated intentions: voters with restrictive preferences reduce consequential campaign support for the CDU and become more likely to seek information from the AfD. Mainstream-party positioning shapes far-right support by determining which voters the mainstream leaves politically unrepresented.

Keywords: Far-Right Parties, Elections, Information Provision Experiment, Immigration.
JEL Codes: D72, C93, K37.

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1 Introduction

Far-right parties have gained substantial electoral support across Western democracies, with important consequences for public policy and economic performance (Funke et al., 2023; Guriev and Papaioannou, 2023). Much of the literature explains this growth through changes in voter demand, including trade exposure, economic insecurity, and new communication technologies (Autor et al., 2020; Colantone and Stanig, 2018; Fetzer, 2019; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). This paper studies a complementary force on the supply side of electoral competition: the positions offered by mainstream parties. On immigration and other cultural issues, European mainstream parties are often perceived as more liberal than the voters they seek to represent (Guenther, 2026). We ask whether this mismatch causally expands the electorate available to the far right.

Spatial voting theory gives a simple but heterogeneous answer. When a center-right party is perceived as moving left, voters to its right become more distant from their closest mainstream option and may defect to the far right. Voters to its left instead become better represented, while voters near the party's position have little reason to change their behavior. The population-average effect is therefore not a structural constant: it aggregates responses that depend on where voters stand relative to the party. A small average can coexist with large effects among politically relevant voter groups.

Estimating this positional channel from actual party movements is difficult. Repositioning changes more than policy distance. It can alter issue salience, the credibility of the party's commitments, coalition expectations, media coverage, and the perceived legitimacy of previously stigmatized positions. Recent quasi-experimental studies of mainstream-party accommodation consequently estimate the bundled effects of particular political events and reach different conclusions (Becker and Hager, 2025; Turnbull-Dugarte et al., 2026).[1] These estimates are valuable for evaluating the events themselves, but they cannot reveal how much of the response is due to perceived policy distance.

We isolate that channel in an information-provision experiment conducted with 5,040 German citizens during the campaign preceding the February 2025 federal election. Participants receive truthful information derived from candidate survey data that places the center-right

[1] Heyna et al. (2026) study cooperation between the CDU and AfD at the local level.

CDU at one of four positions on a common 0–10 immigration scale. Information about every other party is held constant. Assignment is randomized separately within each of the eleven values of respondents' pre-treatment immigration attitudes, allowing us to estimate treatment effects across the voter distribution using randomized comparisons. The experiment measures vote intentions, party attitudes, felt representation, and pre-registered consequential behaviors, including information seeking, real-stakes donations, and the allocation of future campaign advertisements.

The information strongly changes beliefs about the CDU's position. A one-unit change in the randomized signal moves posterior beliefs by approximately one-half of a unit, with a first-stage F-statistic of 375. The effect on beliefs is essentially constant across voters' own immigration attitudes. The signal does not change respondents' own policy positions, their beliefs about the AfD's position, or their expectations about party vote shares and governing coalitions. The experiment therefore shifts the perceived location of the CDU without detectably shifting the other principal inputs into the spatial comparison.

Political responses are concentrated among voters with restrictive immigration preferences. For these voters, a signal portraying the CDU as one unit more liberal raises AfD vote intention by 1.7 percentage points. The signal-based 2SLS estimate is 3.5 percentage points per unit of perceived position. Standard 2SLS gives greater weight to voters whose beliefs respond more strongly to the signal. We therefore also apply the recent Local Least Squares (LLS) method of Balla-Elliott (2026), developed specifically for information-provision experiments, to recover the equally weighted average response among voters who update toward the information. This estimate is 4.7 percentage points. The pre-registered party-support indexes reinforce the vote result: AfD support rises and CDU support falls among voters with restrictive preferences, with the sharpest estimates when belief updaters are weighted equally. Liberal and moderate voters display no comparable robust political response.

The behavioral outcomes reinforce this substitution pattern. Voters with restrictive preferences reduce consequential campaign support for the CDU, while movement toward the AfD appears primarily in greater information seeking. The real-stakes donation margin is less responsive. Felt representation provides direct evidence on the underlying mechanism:

a signal portraying the CDU as more liberal makes voters with restrictive preferences feel less represented by the CDU and voters with liberal preferences feel more represented. These responses offset in the aggregate, producing an average close to zero even though representation changes systematically on both sides of the policy space. The political-response signs are also inconsistent with a legitimation mechanism operating through perceived position alone: among restrictive voters, a more conservative CDU signal reduces rather than increases support for the AfD.

The distribution of voter preferences governs how these group responses aggregate. The experimental sample deliberately oversamples East Germany, where the response is concentrated, so its unweighted average exceeds an aggregate reweighted to the national distribution. More generally, holding group responses fixed while changing the distribution of immigration attitudes moves the aggregate treatment effect from essentially zero in a more liberal electorate to 1.2 percentage points per signal unit in a more conservative one. The returns to perceived repositioning therefore depend on where the electorate stands.

The paper makes two main contributions. First, it provides causal evidence on the positional component of the debate over accommodation and demarcation from the radical right (Abou-Chadi and Krause, 2020; Hjorth and Larsen, 2022). Information-provision and related survey experiments have shown that party positions can affect political evaluations (Chou et al., 2021; Grewenig et al., 2020; Hjorth and Larsen, 2022); by varying perceived position while holding rhetoric, party identity, and coalition behavior fixed, our experiment identifies the policy-distance channel and shows that it is spatially structured. This result also explains why accommodation can have different effects across settings: the effect depends on the location of the accommodating party and on the distribution of voter preferences.

Second, the paper connects political representation to electoral behavior. Existing evidence documents widespread gaps between voter preferences and party positions, while Castanho Silva and Wratil (2023) experimentally study whether learning that some party represents one's views changes general populist attitudes. We instead manipulate the perceived position of a specific mainstream competitor to the far right and measure both felt representation and choices among parties. The results show that representation gaps can change electoral support even when

they do not change voters' underlying policy preferences. They complement accounts based on economic and technological shocks by showing how the political offer determines whether disaffected voters move toward the far right.

2 Setting and Predictions

2.1 Political Setting

Germany has a proportional parliamentary system historically anchored by the center-right Christian Democratic Union of Germany and its Bavarian sister party (CDU/CSU, henceforth CDU) and the center-left Social Democratic Party (SPD). The far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD), founded in 2013, entered the Bundestag in 2017 and became the first party to the right of the CDU to obtain sustained national parliamentary representation since the consolidation of the postwar party system. This makes the CDU the AfD's closest mainstream competitor on the principal policy dimension studied here.

Immigration provides an especially clear setting in which to examine positional competition. Figure 1 uses the German Longitudinal Election Study (GLES, 2023) to compare voters' immigration preferences with their perceptions of party positions from 2009 to 2023. Throughout this period, the average voter perceived every mainstream party, including the CDU, as more liberal on immigration than themselves. The AfD occupied the otherwise open portion of the policy space to the CDU's right. The gap widened during the 2015–16 refugee crisis, when the CDU was perceived as moving in a more liberal direction and AfD support rose sharply. This descriptive series does not establish that the gap caused the AfD's growth, but it identifies the political configuration that motivates our experiment. By the 2025 campaign, the AfD polled at approximately 20%, ranking second behind the CDU.

The 2025 campaign combined a salient immigration debate with substantial uncertainty about the CDU's position. Friedrich Merz's leadership suggested a more restrictive direction than that of recent CDU governments, but voters' pre-treatment beliefs remained widely dispersed. The four positions used in the experiment therefore represented plausible descriptions of the party rather than obviously false alternatives. Germany's "cordon sanitaire," an informal agreement

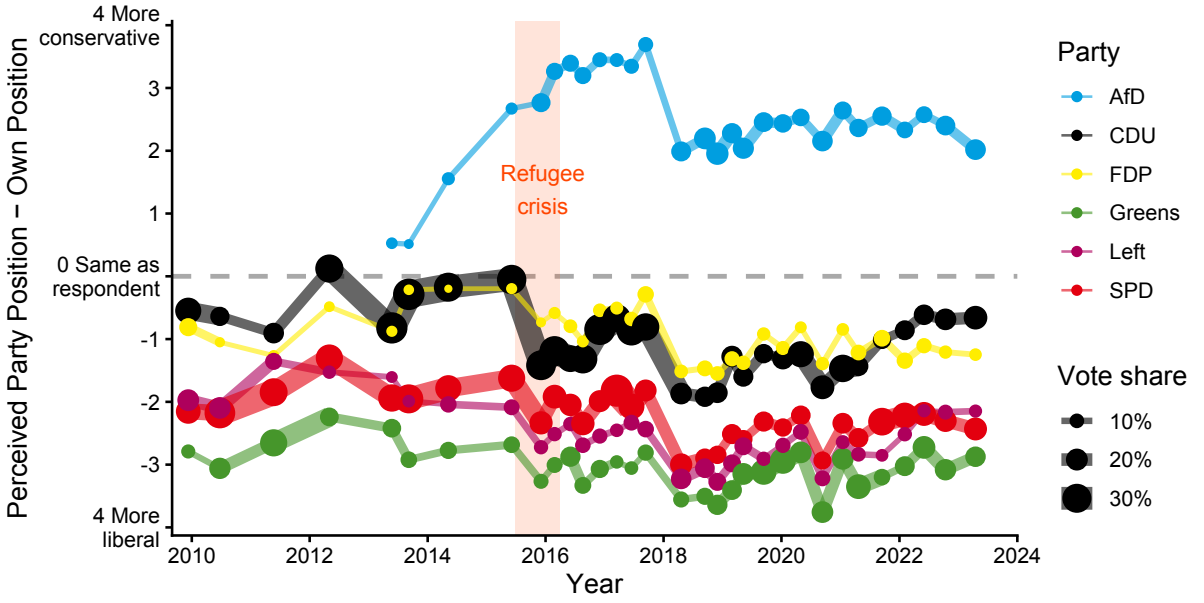


Figure 1: Perceived Immigration Stance of German Parties Relative to Voters
Note: Each point plots the weighted average of (perceived party position − respondent's own position) on a 0–10 immigration scale across all respondents in a given GLES wave. Positive values indicate that voters perceive the party as more conservative than themselves; negative values indicate more liberal. Point size is proportional to the party's vote intention share. The shaded region marks the 2015–16 refugee crisis. Source: GLES (2023).

among mainstream parties not to cooperate with the AfD, also made movement between the CDU and AfD politically consequential. A parliamentary motion passed with AfD support in late January, during our field period, placing that boundary under unusual pressure (Becker and Hager, 2025).

2.2 Spatial Predictions

We organize the empirical analysis with a spatial voting model in which the effect of a party's perceived position varies systematically across the electorate. Voter i has an ideal immigration position $x_i \in [0, 10]$ and holds a belief m_i about the CDU's position, with larger values denoting more restrictive positions. Voter i evaluates party p by quadratic policy loss, $V_i(p) = -(x_i - \pi_p)^2 + v_p$, where π_p is the party's perceived position and v_p captures non-positional valence. For exposition, define $\ell_i = -m_i$, so that an increase in ℓ_i is a more liberal perceived CDU position.

Two predictions follow directly.[2] First, a *single-crossing* property: the effect of a liberal

[2]Formal statements and proofs are in Appendix B. The vote-probability prediction additionally requires that the CDU–AfD margin is the relevant one for voters to the CDU's right, a condition stated there.

shift in the perceived CDU position on the relative attractiveness of the AfD versus the CDU increases with x_i. For voters to the CDU's right, a liberal shift widens their distance to the CDU while leaving their distance to the AfD unchanged, making the AfD relatively more attractive. For voters to the CDU's left, the same shift brings the CDU closer. For voters near the CDU's perceived position, it has little effect on relative distance.

Second, an *aggregation* property: the population effect is the composition-weighted average of these heterogeneous responses. Because responses vary across the policy space, a modest average is compatible with large effects in one part of the electorate. The aggregate depends on the distribution of voter positions, not only on individual responsiveness.

The model also predicts how perceived positioning affects *felt representation*. If representation declines with the distance between a voter and a party, a liberal CDU shift reduces felt representation among voters to the CDU's right and increases it among voters to the CDU's left. These responses can offset in the aggregate even when representation changes systematically within groups. In Germany, where most respondents place themselves to the right of their perceived CDU position, the model predicts the strongest political response among voters with restrictive immigration preferences.

2.3 Alternative Predictions

Two prominent alternatives make different predictions within the channel our experiment manipulates. Under a *protest voting* account, far-right support expresses generalized discontent rather than policy proximity; a marginal change in the perceived position of a mainstream party should then have little systematic effect, and no effect that varies with the voter's own position in the predicted direction. Under a *legitimation* account, perceiving a mainstream party as closer to the far right may validate positions previously considered extreme. A more conservative CDU signal would then increase AfD support alongside CDU support, particularly among voters with restrictive attitudes. The spatial account instead predicts substitution between the parties for those voters. The experiment distinguishes these predictions for the positional-information channel. It does not rule out protest or legitimation mechanisms operating through rhetoric, public elite cues, coalition behavior, or repeated exposure.

3 Experimental Design

3.1 Sample and Procedure

We designed the survey in Qualtrics and recruited participants through the market-research company Cint. The survey was fielded from December 16, 2024, to February 22, 2025; the federal election took place on February 23. As pre-registered, we targeted 5,000 German adults broadly representative in gender, age, and education, with an oversample of Eastern states because AfD support is historically stronger there. The resulting analysis sample contains 5,040 participants, 3,037 from East Germany and 2,003 from West Germany. The median completion time was 10.4 minutes.

Participants first report their own immigration attitude and their beliefs about each major party's immigration position. Both are elicited on the same 0–10 scale, where 0 means that immigration opportunities should be strongly facilitated and 10 that they should be strongly restricted. Participants then receive information about party positions, report posterior beliefs, and complete the outcome blocks. Placing voters, party beliefs, and experimental signals on the same scale allows us to test the spatial predictions directly. Appendix Figure A.1 displays the full survey sequence, and Appendix L reproduces the question wording and outcome construction.

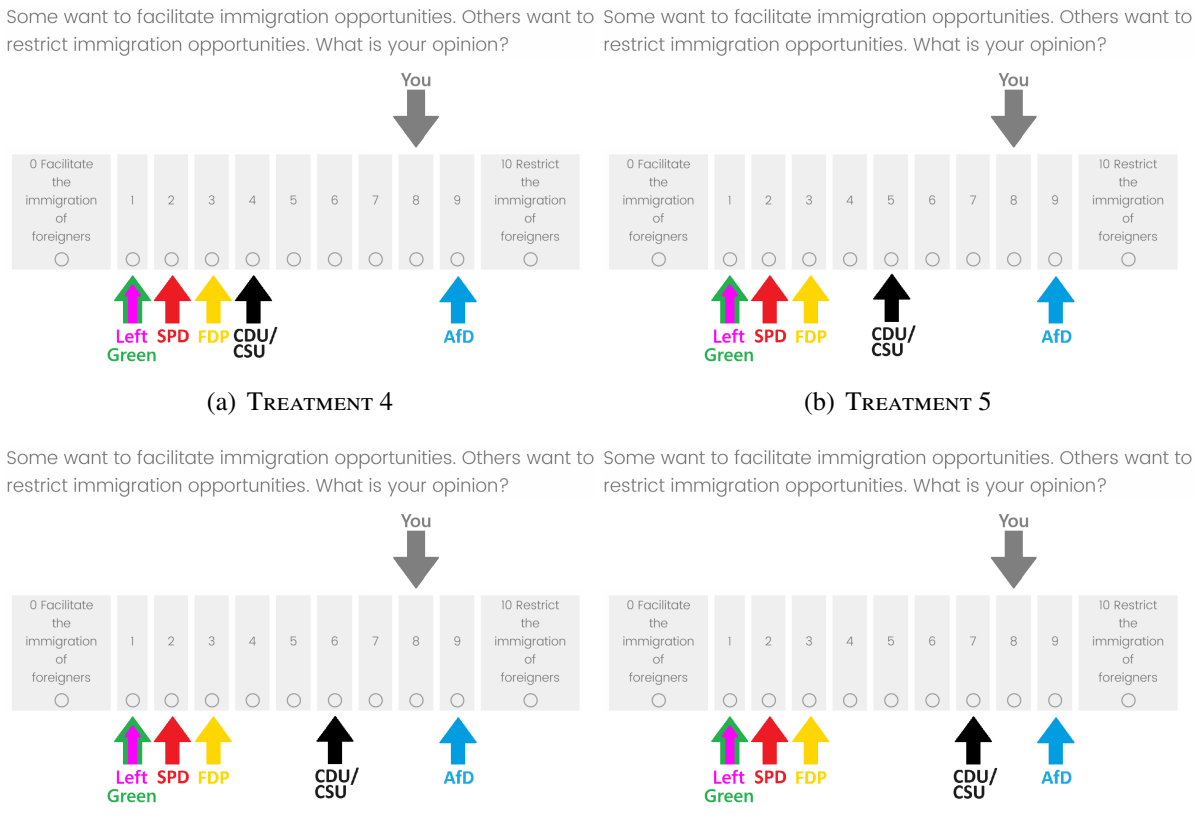
Assignment to the four signals was randomized separately within each of the eleven pre-treatment attitude values. The survey instrument branches on this variable, making the treatment comparison within every exact attitude value a randomized experiment. For exposition, we combine these strata into liberal (0–4), moderate (5–6), and restrictive (7–10) groups. These cutoffs were chosen after data collection and were not specified in the pre-analysis plan; Appendix A reports this and the other deviations together. Grouping the strata does not alter the randomized basis of the within-group treatment comparisons.

Participants who failed the initial captcha or attention check were screened out and contributed no data. Following the survey firm's operational rule, 87 respondents completing the survey in less than one-third of the soft-launch median were replaced during data collection and excluded from the main analysis. This exclusion was not pre-registered, so we report estimates including these respondents as a robustness check. Treatment arms are balanced on pre-treatment

attitudes and party-position beliefs, and information trust does not differ across arms (Appendix Table A.2).

3.2 Treatment: The CDU Position Signal

We construct party-position information from surveys of candidates in the 2021 federal election who answered the same immigration question as our participants. Following previous work, we measure a party's position by the median response of its candidates (Costello et al., 2020; Dalton, 2017; Guenther, 2026; Vasilopoulou and Gattermann, 2013; Walczak and Van der Brug, 2013). The positions shown for the AfD, SPD, Greens, FDP, and Left are fixed at the medians of all available candidates. The CDU position is the median in a subsample of 11 of the 141 available CDU candidates. Actual subsamples produce four signal values with high probability: 4, 5, 6, and 7. We assign these values with equal probability to maximize power. Every value shown to participants is therefore a truthful summary of actual candidate responses, and the survey explains both the source and the number of candidates used. Appendix L reproduces the full text.



(a) Treatment 4

(b) Treatment 5

(c) Treatment 6

(d) Treatment 7

Figure 2: Information Provision Screen by Treatment

Figure 2 shows the four treatment screens. Participants also see their own attitude on the common scale and a short verbal description of each party's position. Our endogenous variable is the participant's post-treatment belief about the CDU's immigration position. Because the survey's raw scale assigns larger values to more restrictive positions, while the paper states effects in the more intuitive liberal direction, we define Liberal Signal$_i$ = −Raw Signal$_i$ and Liberal Posterior$_i$ = −Raw Posterior$_i$. This sign reversal preserves units: a one-unit increase in either analysis variable is a one-unit more liberal position. All reported coefficients follow this convention unless explicitly labeled as raw survey values.

3.3 Outcomes

The primary stated outcomes are indicators for intending to vote for the AfD and CDU. The pre-registered AfD- and CDU-support indexes summarize vote intention, a feeling thermometer, a party-newsletter link click, a real-stakes donation measure, and the allocation of official campaign advertisements to participants in a future study. Each component is standardized and signed so that higher values indicate greater party support; the first principal component is then standardized. Turnout is analyzed separately.

The three behavioral components capture distinct margins. Newsletter-link clicks measure information seeking. The donation task elicits the minimum compensation required for participants to permit a real €5 donation to the CDU or AfD on their behalf, using the staircase method of Falk et al. (2018). The campaign measure gives participants a consequential choice over how many of 1,000 future study participants will see each party's official advertisement. We also pre-registered felt representation by the CDU on a 1–7 scale as the mechanism outcome. Appendix L gives the full wording and construction of every outcome.

The study was approved by the Bocconi University Research Ethics Committee (Application RA000845) and pre-registered before data collection. We also conducted a pre-registered obfuscated follow-up approximately one week later to assess persistence and experimenter demand. Because recontact was 43.3%, we treat it as secondary and report its design, attrition analysis, and results together in Appendix K.

4 Empirical Strategy and Identification

We report three estimands. The reduced form is the direct causal effect of the randomized signal. Two-stage least squares (2SLS) translates that effect into units of perceived CDU position, weighting individual effects by the strength of belief updating. Local Least Squares (LLS) instead gives equal weight to voters who update toward the signal. Together, the estimators distinguish the effect of the information intervention from the average response to a unit change in perceived position.

4.1 Reduced Form

As pre-registered, we treat the four-level signal as continuous and estimate

$$y_i = \alpha + \beta \cdot \text{Liberal Signal}_i + \theta X_i + \varepsilon_i, \tag{1}$$

where y_i is an outcome and Liberal Signal_i is the sign-reversed treatment value defined in Section 3.2. The coefficient β is the causal effect of receiving a signal that portrays the CDU as one unit more liberal. In every pooled and within-group design-based specification, X_i contains age, gender, immigration background, East Germany, education, and categorical indicators for the pre-treatment CDU belief. These controls affect precision rather than identification. The pre-registered variant adding priors about the other parties yields nearly identical estimates and is reported in the replication output.

4.2 Estimating the Effect of CDU Positioning

To estimate the causal effect of perceived CDU position, we instrument the liberal-coded posterior belief with the liberal-coded randomized signal. The first stage is

$$\text{Liberal Posterior}_i = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \cdot \text{Liberal Signal}_i + \delta X_i + \eta_i, \tag{2}$$

and the second stage is

$$y_i = \alpha + \beta \cdot \widehat{\text{Liberal Posterior}}_i + \theta X_i + \varepsilon_i. \tag{3}$$

The coefficient β is measured per one-unit more liberal perceived CDU position. The exclusion restriction requires the signal to affect outcomes through beliefs about the CDU's immigration stance. Section 5.1 reports pre-registered checks for changes in respondents' own attitudes, other party beliefs, coalition expectations, and expected vote shares.

4.3 The LLS Estimator

Standard 2SLS identifies a causal average weighted by the strength of individual belief updating (Imbens and Angrist, 1994). This weighting need not provide a representative average response: voters with more precise prior beliefs may update less even when the party's position matters more for their choices. Following Balla-Elliott (2026), we therefore complement 2SLS with LLS, a recent identification method tailored to information-provision experiments. LLS replaces learning-rate weights with equal weights and recovers the average response among positive belief updaters under the maintained learning-rate assumptions.

The estimator conditions on each respondent's learning rate,

$$\alpha_i = \frac{\text{posterior}_i - \text{prior}_i}{\text{signal}_i - \text{prior}_i}.$$

Holding the learning rate and prior fixed, posterior beliefs vary through the randomized signal. Local regressions within narrow bands of the learning-rate distribution therefore use experimental variation in perceived position. We exclude cases in which prior and signal coincide, non-updaters, and respondents who update away from the signal, so the LLS estimand is the equally weighted average among positive updaters.

Our main specification uses categorical indicators for the pre-treatment CDU belief, an Epanechnikov kernel, bandwidth $h = .10$, automatic boundary trimming, and 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws. Conditioning on the CDU prior is necessary: without it, the estimator produces a non-causal association with a pre-treatment placebo; with it, both pre-treatment

placebo coefficients are statistically indistinguishable from zero (Appendix J). Appendix F documents the implementation and local-identification diagnostics, while Appendix H reports bandwidth, updater, rank, control, and sample variants.

Every LLS estimate is accompanied by its reduced-form and 2SLS benchmarks. RF and 2SLS use the full non-speeder sample; restricting them to positive updaters would condition on a post-treatment outcome and sacrifice their design-based interpretation. RF effects are measured per signal unit, while 2SLS and LLS effects are measured per posterior-belief unit. The three estimates are therefore complementary rather than interchangeable.

5 Results

5.1 First Stage and Exclusion Checks

We begin by describing where voters and parties sit in the policy space. Figure 3 plots participants' immigration attitudes alongside their post-treatment beliefs about party positions on the common raw 0–10 scale. Participants' attitudes skew toward restriction: the AfD's perceived stance is closest to the sample mean, median, and mode, while every other party, including the CDU, is perceived as more liberal than the average respondent. The population-reweighted distribution remains concentrated to the CDU's right. This is the configuration in which the spatial model predicts that a liberal perceived CDU shift will move voters toward the AfD.

The signal moves CDU beliefs as intended. Participants receiving a raw signal of 4 report a posterior of approximately 4.7, while those receiving a signal of 7 report a posterior of 6.2. A one-unit signal change moves the posterior by 0.497 units in the same direction, with a first-stage F-statistic of 375. The effect also extends to respondents' belief about where the CDU will stand five years later, which moves by 0.37 units per signal unit. Participants therefore interpret the information as revealing a durable party position rather than a transitory survey fact. The pre-registered manipulation check agrees: the mean absolute distance between beliefs and the signal falls from 2.57 to 1.84 ($p < .001$ under both the paired t-test and Wilcoxon signed-rank test; Appendix Table C.3).

The exclusion restriction requires the signal to affect political outcomes through the

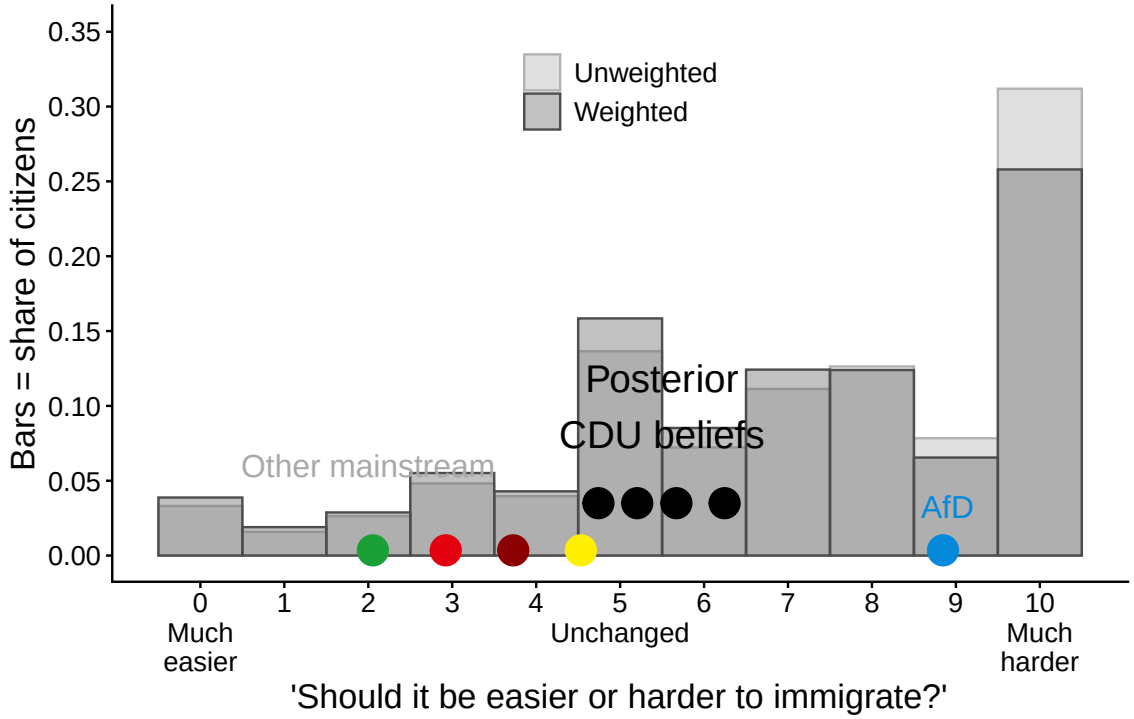


Figure 3: Post-Treatment Beliefs about CDU Immigration Stance by Treatment
Note: Bars show participants' own immigration attitudes. Unweighted bars include the original sample (East Germans over-represented); weighted bars correct for this. Black circles show average post-treatment beliefs about the CDU immigration stance for each treatment. Colored circles show average post-treatment beliefs about other parties, pooling treatments.

perceived CDU position. A central threat is *cross-learning*: respondents might update other beliefs at the same time (Haaland et al., 2023). The pre-registered checks find no economically meaningful effects on respondents' own immigration attitudes, the perceived AfD position, expected governing coalitions, or expected CDU and AfD vote shares (Appendix C). The only other-party position effect reaching conventional significance is for the FDP, at 0.079 units per signal unit ($p = .024$), less than one-sixth of the CDU first stage. These results substantially narrow the set of competing channels through which the signal could operate.

Two further checks establish that the political heterogeneity below is not differential exposure to the treatment. The first-stage interaction between the signal and respondents' own attitudes is close to zero and precisely estimated (-0.006, 95% CI $[-0.026, 0.013]$, $p = .52$). The same belief shift therefore reaches voters across the policy space. The signal also does not move the stated importance of immigration in the full sample (-0.018, $p = .15$) or among respondents with restrictive preferences (-0.024, $p = .11$). Because importance is measured after the outcome blocks, this last check bounds rather than eliminates a salience response.

5.2 Main Results: Effects Across the Policy Space

We now turn to the model's central prediction. Assignment was randomized within each of the eleven pre-treatment attitude values, so every grouped estimate combines randomized comparisons. Figures 4 and 5 report reduced-form, 2SLS, and LLS effects on AfD and CDU vote intentions and the pre-registered party-support indexes.

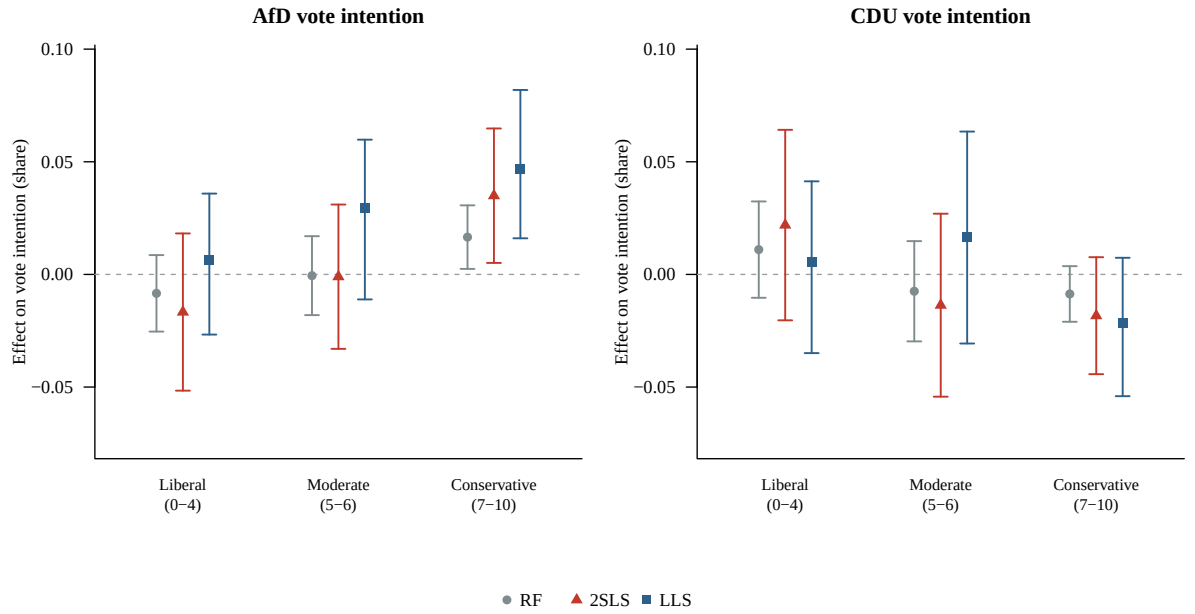


Figure 4: Effects on vote intentions by own immigration attitude.
Note: Points show coefficient estimates and bars show 95% confidence intervals. Positive coefficients mean that a more liberal CDU position or signal increases the probability of intending to vote for the named party. RF is per randomized-signal unit; 2SLS and LLS are per posterior-belief unit. RF and 2SLS use the full group samples, demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls, and HC1 inference. LLS uses positive updaters, categorical CDU-prior controls, $h = .10$, group-specific normalized ranks, automatic trimming, and 500 Bayesian-bootstrap draws.

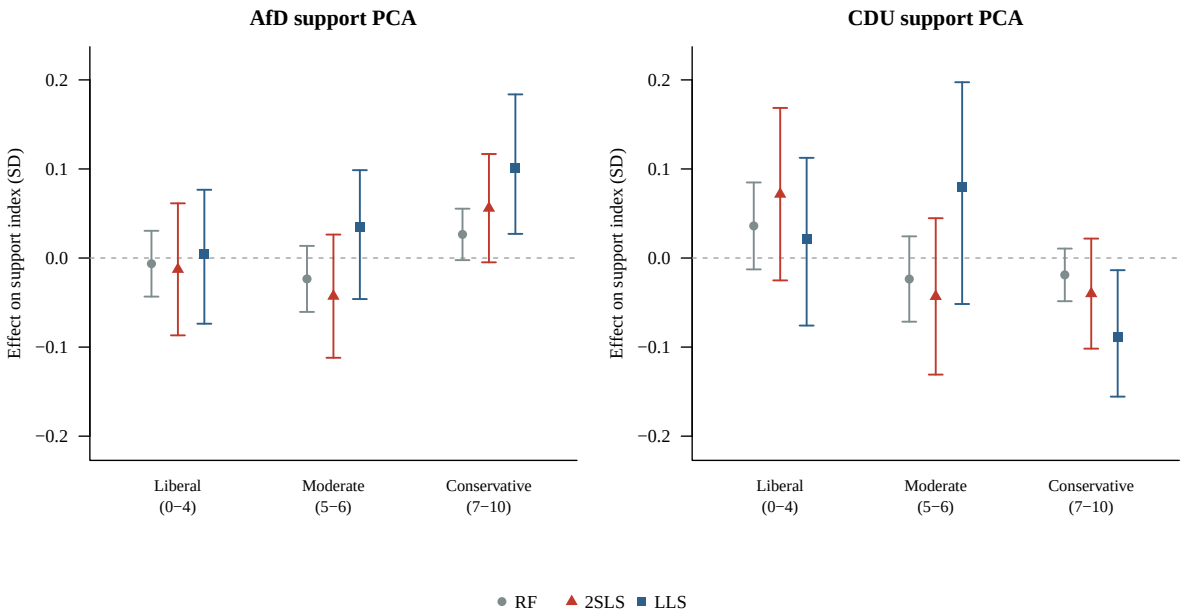


Figure 5: Effects on party-support indexes by own immigration attitude.
Note: Points show coefficient estimates and bars show 95% confidence intervals. Positive coefficients mean that a more liberal CDU position or signal increases support for the named party. RF is per randomized-signal unit; 2SLS and LLS are per posterior-belief unit. RF and 2SLS use the full group samples, demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls, and HC1 inference. LLS uses positive updaters, categorical CDU-prior controls, $h = .10$, group-specific normalized ranks, automatic trimming, and 500 Bayesian-bootstrap draws.

The response is concentrated where the spatial model predicts it should be strongest. Among voters with restrictive preferences, a one-unit more liberal signal raises AfD vote intention by 1.7 percentage points ($p = .022$). The corresponding effect per unit of perceived CDU position is 3.5 percentage points in 2SLS (95% CI $[0.5, 6.5]$, $p = .022$) and 4.7 percentage points under equal-updater LLS weighting ($[1.6, 8.2]$, $p = .004$). Liberal voters do not move (LLS +0.7 percentage points, $p = .66$); the moderate estimate lies between the liberal and restrictive estimates but is not robustly distinguishable from zero. The CDU vote response among restrictive voters is directionally consistent (−2.1 percentage points in LLS, $p = .16$). The concentration of the AfD response does not depend on the three post-hoc bins. Using all eleven randomization strata, the reduced-form effect on AfD vote intention increases by 0.34 percentage points for each one-point more restrictive pre-treatment attitude (SE = 0.16, $p = .036$); the saturated stratum estimates are consistent with the same gradient (Appendix Figure E.2).

The pre-registered support indexes reinforce the vote-intention result. Among voters with restrictive preferences, all three estimators point toward substitution from the CDU to the AfD.

Under the equal-updater weighting proposed by Balla-Elliott (2026), the AfD index rises by 0.101 standard deviations ($p = .009$) and the CDU index falls by 0.089 standard deviations ($p = .011$). The randomized reduced form yields effects of +0.027 and −0.019 standard deviations per signal unit, and 2SLS yields +0.056 and −0.040 standard deviations per unit of perceived position. These estimates are economically meaningful and have the same signs, although their confidence intervals are wider. As in the broader evidence documented by Balla-Elliott (2026), the equally weighted estimates are larger than the update-weighted 2SLS estimates. None of the liberal or moderate LLS index coefficients is statistically significant; the restrictive–moderate contrast is sharpest for CDU support ($p = .020$).

The signs are inconsistent with a legitimation mechanism operating through perceived position alone. Such a mechanism predicts that a more conservative CDU signal should raise support for the AfD and CDU together among voters with restrictive preferences. Instead, a more liberal perceived CDU position lowers CDU support and raises AfD support. The pattern is spatial substitution rather than joint validation.

The behavioral outcomes reinforce this substitution pattern. Every behavioral-index coefficient among voters with restrictive preferences has the predicted sign. Under equal-updater weighting, the AfD behavioral index rises by 0.089 standard deviations ($p = .015$) and the CDU behavioral index falls by 0.081 standard deviations ($p = .032$); the reduced-form and 2SLS counterparts point in the same directions. The components reveal distinct margins of response (Appendix Table G.17). Voters reduce the share of future campaign exposure they allocate to the CDU, an effect significant at every bandwidth from $h = .05$ to $h = .15$. Movement toward the AfD appears primarily in newsletter-link clicks, which increase through $h = .10$. The real-stakes donation margin is less responsive. The thermometers move with the corresponding party indexes, while abstention is unchanged (Appendix Table G.18).

5.3 Mechanism: Felt Representation

The spatial account operates through representation: moving a party changes which voters see it as speaking for them. A signal portraying the CDU as one unit more liberal moves perceived distance and felt representation in opposite directions on the two sides of the policy space

(Figure 6). Among liberal respondents, perceived distance to the CDU falls by 0.52 points and felt representation rises by 0.145 points ($p = .003$). Among respondents with restrictive preferences, perceived distance rises by 0.48 points and felt representation falls by 0.078 points ($p = .002$). Neither outcome moves among moderates. In the pooled sample, the representation responses offset almost exactly (-0.03, $p = .12$): the aggregate null conceals the mechanism operating on both sides of the policy space.

The magnitude is notable because the treatment changes only one component of political representation: where voters believe the CDU stands on a single issue. This deliberately narrow intervention moves the broader felt-representation measure by only 0.04 to 0.08 standard deviations, yet produces economically meaningful changes in electoral support. The result underscores how consequential even modest representation gaps can be when they separate voters from their closest mainstream option. Because the experiment directly manipulates perceived party position rather than felt representation itself, we interpret the representation results as evidence about the mechanism without rescaling the electoral estimates by this intermediate response.

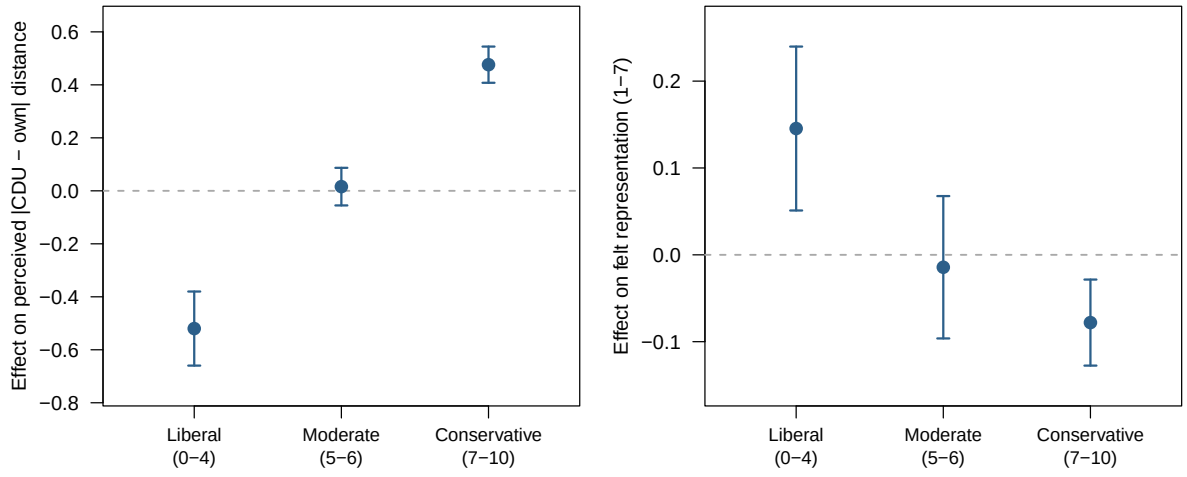


Figure 6: Effects on perceived distance and felt representation, by own immigration attitude.
Note: Reduced-form estimates of the effect of a signal portraying the CDU as one unit more liberal, within randomization strata grouped into three attitude bins. Left panel: perceived distance |CDU − own position|. Right panel: felt representation by the CDU (1–7 scale). Bars are 95% confidence intervals (HC1). Controls: demographics and categorical CDU-prior indicators.

5.4 Geography and Aggregation

Geography provides an important composition check. In East Germany, a one-unit more liberal perceived CDU position raises AfD vote intention by 4.1 percentage points in 2SLS (95% CI $[1.0, 7.2]$, $p = .010$) and by 3.5 to 4.3 percentage points in LLS, depending on controls. In West Germany, every estimator is close to zero (2SLS −0.6 percentage points, 95% CI $[-3.3, 2.1]$; Appendix Table D.7). Because the experiment deliberately oversamples East Germany, the unweighted experimental average places more weight on the responsive region than an aggregate reweighted to the national East–West distribution. The geographic split therefore helps explain why nationally representative effects are smaller than the experimental-sample average. Appendix D reports the other pre-registered heterogeneity dimensions, none of which displays a comparably coherent contrast.

Pooled effects. Pooled estimates average over the heterogeneous responses. A one-unit more liberal perceived CDU position raises AfD vote intention by 3.1 percentage points in LLS ($p = .017$) and 2.1 percentage points in 2SLS ($p = .047$); the CDU vote response is negative across estimators. The pooled party-support indexes also move in the predicted directions: +0.046 standard deviations for the AfD and −0.052 for the CDU under equal-updater weighting. Table 1 reports these estimates. Appendix I shows that adding the AfD prior is immaterial and that dropping demographics moves the pooled LLS indexes toward larger CDU effects.

Table 1: Pooled posterior effects on vote intentions and the all-outcome PCA indexes

	AfD vote		CDU vote		AfD index		CDU index	
Method	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p
RF	0.011	.047	−0.006	.206	0.013	.256	−0.015	.227
2SLS	0.021	.047	−0.013	.206	0.026	.254	−0.029	.225
LLS	0.031	.017	−0.014	.221	0.046	.099	−0.052	.065

Notes: Controls in every row: categorical CDU-prior indicators plus age, gender, immigration background, East Germany, and education. RF is per randomized-signal unit; 2SLS and LLS are per posterior-belief unit. RF/2SLS use all 5,040 non-speeders and HC1 inference. LLS uses 2,654 positive updaters, $h = .10$, official normalized ranks, automatic trimming, and 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws; p-values use the 1% tail-trimmed bootstrap standard deviation. Vote effects are in shares (0.031 = 3.1 percentage points); index effects in standard deviations. Appendix I reports the CDU-prior-only and added-AfD-prior control variants.

The aggregation result can also be taken directly to the randomized signal. Weighting

attitude-specific reduced forms by the observed experimental attitude distribution gives an AfD-vote effect of 0.9 percentage points per signal unit ($p = .079$). Holding group responses fixed, shifting the electorate one point in the liberal direction reduces the aggregate to -0.1 percentage points ($p = .93$); shifting it one point in the restrictive direction raises the aggregate to 1.2 percentage points ($p = .047$).[3] The aggregate effect of perceived repositioning is therefore a function of the electorate's preference distribution.

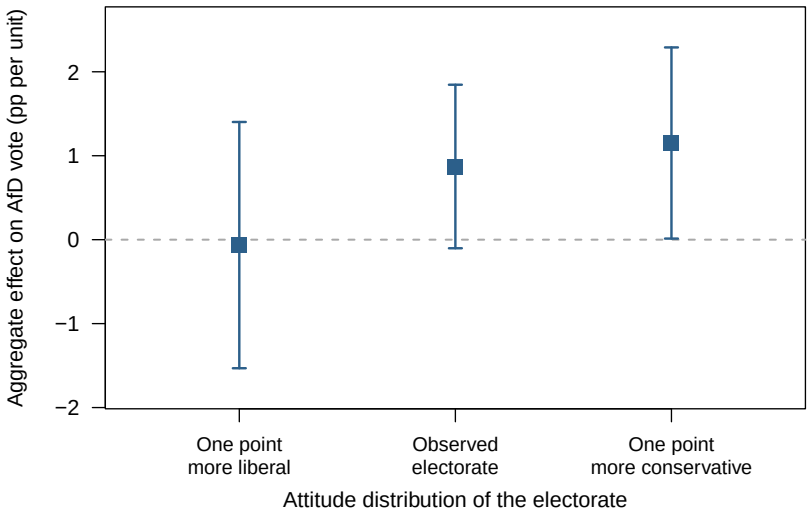


Figure 7: Aggregate effect on AfD vote intention under counterfactual attitude distributions.
Note: Composition-weighted aggregates of stratum-level reduced-form effects, holding stratum responses fixed. Bars are 95% confidence intervals (delta method over stratum coefficients, HC1).

5.5 Robustness and Persistence

The main result survives the pre-registered sample restrictions and the inclusion of the 87 speeders: the AfD-vote effect among voters with restrictive preferences is statistically significant in every reported sample and estimator (Appendix Table F.15). It is also insensitive to moving the threshold that defines restrictive preferences. Extending the group to $x \geq 6$ produces similar estimates, while restricting it to $x \geq 8$ produces larger AfD effects under RF, 2SLS, and LLS (Appendix Table E.9). The all-outcome LLS signs and magnitudes also persist under alternative updater and rank rules. Across bandwidths from $h = .05$ to $h = .15$, the restrictive-group CDU effect is significant throughout, while the AfD effect is significant through $h = .10$ and marginal

[3]This is a partial-equilibrium transport: it holds group-level responses fixed while varying composition and abstracts from campaign and party responses.

at wider bandwidths (Appendix H). A saturated reduced form finds no evidence of nonlinearity across the four treatment arms for either vote intention or either party-support index ($p \geq .49$). Finally, the pre-treatment placebo audit confirms the importance of conditioning on the CDU prior: under the main specification, neither placebo coefficient differs statistically from zero (Appendix J).

The obfuscated follow-up leaves the duration of the response unresolved. At the main bandwidth, the pooled AfD-vote estimate is 1.1 percentage points with a 95% interval of $[-2.2, 4.3]$; the design-based estimates are also statistically indistinguishable from both persistence and decay. Although recontact was 43.3%, treatment assignment does not predict attrition ($p = .63$), and inverse-probability weighting produces similar point estimates. Appendix K reports the full design and results. We therefore interpret the main experiment as identifying the short-run electoral response to perceived positioning during an active campaign.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

The magnitude of the response is notable because the treatment changes only one input into political evaluations: the perceived position of one party on one issue. This deliberately narrow intervention moves the broader felt-representation measure by only 0.04 to 0.08 standard deviations, yet it produces economically meaningful changes in electoral support. Even a modest representation gap can therefore be consequential when it separates voters from their closest mainstream option.

The behavioral outcomes sharpen this interpretation. The clearest behavioral effect is withdrawal from the mainstream party: voters with restrictive preferences reduce the share of future campaign exposure they allocate to the CDU, and this response persists across the full range of bandwidths. On the AfD side, the response appears primarily in information seeking rather than financial support. The difference across margins is consistent with broader evidence that information treatments often have smaller effects on downstream behavior than on beliefs and that the costs of political action can impede follow-through on stated intentions (Haaland et al., 2023; Hill, 2020). In our setting, changing an intended vote or requesting more information

requires less commitment than authorizing a real donation. The experiment thus captures both sides of political substitution: disengagement from the mainstream party and movement toward the far right, expressed on different behavioral margins.

The experimental effect isolates one component of actual repositioning rather than all of its consequences. Real-world party movements also change rhetoric, salience, coalition expectations, and credibility. These channels can reinforce or offset policy distance, which helps explain why bundled quasi-experimental episodes need not reproduce our estimate (Becker and Hager, 2025; Turnbull-Dugarte et al., 2026). The experiment supplies the missing causal building block: how voters respond when the perceived position changes while those accompanying channels are held fixed.

The composition results also clarify external validity. There is no universal effect of mainstream-party accommodation because the response depends on where voters sit relative to the party. In East Germany and among voters with restrictive preferences, a more liberal perceived CDU position expands the AfD's reach. In West Germany and among liberal voters, it does not. Because East Germany is oversampled in the experiment, the unweighted pooled estimates exceed what national geographic weights imply. More generally, the counterfactual exercise shows that the same group responses aggregate to essentially zero in a more liberal electorate and to a larger AfD gain in a more restrictive one. These are short-run responses during an active campaign; repeated repositioning can additionally change credibility and party strategy.

The distributional structure is the central finding. Mainstream-party positioning determines who feels represented, who withdraws support, and who becomes available to the far right. For the debate over accommodation and demarcation, this reframes the question: the electoral effect of repositioning is not a fixed parameter but a function of the preference distribution. Where mainstream parties are believed to stand determines whom they leave unrepresented and whom the far right can reach.

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A Pre-Analysis Plan, Sample, and Design Details

A.1 Pre-analysis plan and deviations

The experiment and its outcomes were pre-registered before data collection. Six deviations or additions should be read together rather than scattered across the manuscript. First, the pre-analysis plan framed the instrumented analysis in terms of the perceived representation gap; we report beliefs about the CDU's position as the endogenous variable throughout because it is directly observed, maps one-to-one onto the randomized information, and avoids the compound measurement of the gap. Appendix I (Table I.21) reports the pre-registered gap specification itself, in 2SLS and in LLS, for the vote intentions and the support indexes. Second, we exclude 87 speeders using the survey firm's ex ante operational rule; including them is a robustness check. Third, the pre-analysis plan named four heterogeneity dimensions—macro-area of residence, perceived importance of immigration, delegate-versus-trustee views of representation, and primary motivation for voting—but not respondents' own immigration attitude, the dimension on which Section 5.2 stratifies. We report the own-attitude analysis for two reasons: it is the central prediction of the spatial framework of Section 2 (whether a more liberal CDU position pushes a voter toward or away from the far right depends on where the voter stands), and it is design-based (the survey flow randomizes the signal separately within each of the eleven own-attitude levels, so the treatment contrast within every level is itself a randomized experiment). The 0–4, 5–6, and 7–10 grouping is ours and was chosen after data collection. Fourth, the categorical CDU-prior control in subgroup LLS is a study-specific response to local rank deficiency, and the pre-analysis plan's plural prior-beliefs clause is infeasible in the same thin local windows: beyond the CDU prior, we therefore report the design-based all-priors variant in the replication output and show in Appendix I that adding the AfD prior moves no pooled estimate by more than 0.005 standard deviations. The linear-prior version remains a robustness check. Fifth, the LLS sample retains only respondents whose beliefs move toward the signal ($\alpha_i > 0$); the pre-analysis plan listed the exclusion of respondents who update away from the signal as a robustness check rather than as the main sample, so the LLS estimand is the average effect among positive updaters, and Appendix F reports variants that retain negative updaters. Sixth, the pre-analysis plan's

control clause for the instrumented specifications pairs the CDU prior with socio-demographics; the attitude-group LLS regressions drop the demographics for the same local rank-deficiency reason described in the fourth item, while the pooled LLS and every reduced-form and 2SLS specification retain them.

A.2 Sample and balance

Table A.1: Sample accounting

Sample stage	Observations
Completed main survey	5,127
Main analysis sample (non-speeders)	5,040
West Germany	2,003
East Germany	3,037
Any follow-up outcome	2,182
Positive posterior updaters used in pooled LLS	2,654
Attitude groups: liberal / moderate / conservative	823 / 1,052 / 3,165
Positive updaters by group	453 / 579 / 1,622

Table A.2: Randomization and balance summary

Check	Result
Assignment mechanism	Equal-probability randomization across signals 4, 5, 6, and 7 within each of the eleven pre-treatment attitude levels.
Pre-treatment own attitude	Balanced across signal arms; omnibus $p \geq .17$.
Prior party-position beliefs	Balanced across signal arms; omnibus $p \geq .17$.
Signal credibility	Similar across arms.
Follow-up participation	Signal-arm joint test $p = .63$.

Nearly 80% of respondents reported no perceived political bias in the survey, and the remaining responses were approximately symmetric around zero. The deliberate East-Germany oversample is addressed through regional splits and composition reweighting. The main heterogeneity comparison is internally valid without population weights because assignment was randomized within attitude strata.

A.3 Survey flow and response quality

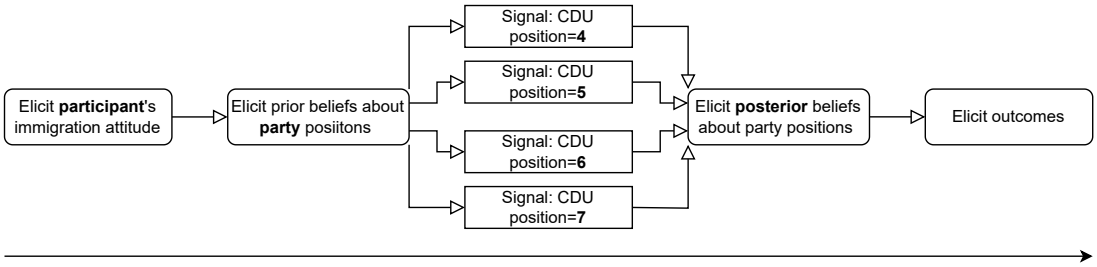


Figure A.1: Survey Structure

Figure A.1 displays the five stages of the main survey: screening and own-attitude elicitation, prior party-position beliefs, randomized party-position information, posterior beliefs, and outcome measurement. The ordering of outcome blocks was randomized where indicated in the instrument. To encourage attentive reporting, participants were told that low-quality responses could be flagged to the recruiting platform (Alesina et al., 2023). Approximately 90% passed the second attention check at the end of the survey. The pre-registered robustness checks exclude respondents failing this check and respondents rating the information as untrustworthy; both preserve the main pattern (Table F.15).

B Formal Spatial Predictions

Let x_i be voter i's immigration ideal point, m_i the perceived CDU position, and π_A the perceived AfD position, all on the survey scale on which larger values are more restrictive. For voters whose relevant choice margin is between the CDU and AfD, the AfD–CDU utility difference, ignoring terms common to the two parties, is

$$\Delta_i(m_i) = -(x_i - \pi_A)^2 + (x_i - m_i)^2 + (v_A - v_C).$$

Define $\ell_i = -m_i$, so that an increase in ℓ_i is a more liberal perceived CDU position. Then

$$\frac{\partial \Delta_i}{\partial \ell_i} = 2(x_i - m_i).$$

This derivative is monotone in the voter's own position and changes sign when the voter crosses the CDU's perceived position. Any smooth voting rule $P_i(A) = G(\Delta_i)$ with $G' > 0$ preserves this single-crossing property:

$$\frac{\partial P_i(A)}{\partial \ell_i} = G'(\Delta_i)\, 2(x_i - m_i).$$

The population effect is the integral of these individual derivatives over the voter distribution. It can therefore be small when group effects are large and opposite-signed. If felt representation is $R_i = r(|x_i - m_i|)$ with $r' < 0$, its response also changes sign at $x_i = m_i$. The framework therefore yields two substantive predictions taken to the data: opposite-signed representation responses and political effects concentrated where the signal moves the CDU away from voters. Equal first-stage updating across groups is not a prediction of the model; it is the design condition that lets us attribute heterogeneous political responses to voter position rather than differential learning.

C Manipulation and Exclusion Checks

C.1 Pre-registered manipulation check

Table C.3: Pre-registered manipulation check: distance between beliefs and the signal

Mean $\lvert s_i - \text{prior}_i \rvert$	2.57
Mean $\lvert s_i - \text{posterior}_i \rvert$	1.84
Mean paired difference	−0.73
Paired t-test p	$< .001$
Wilcoxon signed-rank p	$< .001$
Share strictly closer after signal	0.47
N	5,040

Notes: s_i is the signal received; prior and posterior are the respondent's beliefs about the CDU's position, all on the raw 0–10 scale. Non-speeder sample. The pre-analysis plan specifies this comparison with both parametric and non-parametric tests; the paired t-test and the Wilcoxon signed-rank test agree. The share strictly closer is below one because non-updaters have identical distances before and after.

C.2 Posterior beliefs by attitude group

Table C.4: First-stage and first-stage heterogeneity

Term	Estimate	95% CI	p
Signal → CDU posterior	0.497	[0.446, 0.547]	< .001
Signal × own attitude	−0.006	[−0.026, 0.013]	.522
First-stage F		375	
Observations		5,040	

The first-stage interaction is the key group comparison: liberal, moderate, and restrictive respondents receive essentially the same belief shift from a one-unit signal change. The political heterogeneity cannot therefore be explained by stronger learning among restrictive respondents.

C.3 Other beliefs, own attitudes, salience, and coalition expectations

Table C.5: Selected reduced-form exclusion checks

Post-treatment variable	Signal effect	p
Own immigration attitude	0.001	.987
Importance of immigration, full sample	−0.018	.153
Importance of immigration, conservative group	−0.024	.107
Expected AfD vote share	0.320	.236
Expected CDU vote share	−0.173	.366
Coalition expectations (largest of three)	0.019	.438

Table C.6: Belief spillovers to other parties

Party posterior	Signal effect	p
CDU	0.497	< .001
AfD	0.003	.896
SPD	0.041	.114
Greens	0.005	.870
FDP	0.079	.023
Left	0.024	.406

Respondents also expect the CDU's position five years later to move by approximately 0.37 units per unit of the current signal, about three quarters of the immediate first stage. This indicates that respondents interpret the information as informative about a durable party position rather than as a transitory survey fact. The treatment does not shift own immigration attitudes, so the

experiment changes perceived party location rather than persuading respondents to change their own policy ideal point.

D Additional Heterogeneity Dimensions

Table D.7: East–West heterogeneity

		AfD vote intention			AfD overall PCA		
Region	Method	Effect	95% CI	p	Effect	95% CI	p
East	RF	0.019	[0.005, 0.034]	.010	0.030	[−0.000, 0.061]	.051
	2SLS	0.041	[0.010, 0.072]	.010	0.065	[0.000, 0.129]	.050
	LLS	0.043	[0.009, 0.078]	.011	0.078	[0.015, 0.144]	.024
West	RF	−0.003	[−0.018, 0.011]	.666	−0.017	[−0.049, 0.015]	.304
	2SLS	−0.006	[−0.033, 0.021]	.667	−0.031	[−0.091, 0.029]	.308
	LLS	0.011	[−0.024, 0.042]	.510	0.017	[−0.049, 0.090]	.634

Notes: Estimated separately by region under the main specification. RF and 2SLS: full regional non-speeder samples (N = 3,037 East, 2,003 West), demographic (excluding the East indicator) and categorical CDU-prior controls, HC1 inference. LLS: positive updaters (N = 1,561 East, 1,093 West), region-specific normalized ranks, h = .10, same controls as RF/2SLS, 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws. With categorical-CDU-prior-only local controls, the East LLS vote effect is 0.035 (p = .016) and the West effect 0.002 (p = .91). CDU outcomes are negative and insignificant in the East and null in the West.

Table D.8: Pre-registered heterogeneity dimensions: subgroup effects and interaction tests

	Subgroup 1	Subgroup 2	Interaction
Immigration important: important (N=3,615) vs. not important (N=1,425)			
AfD vote	0.016 (.014)	0.002 (.804)	0.016 (.140)
CDU vote	−0.009 (.146)	−0.000 (.965)	−0.010 (.341)
AfD overall PCA	0.020 (.159)	0.012 (.491)	0.012 (.583)
CDU overall PCA	−0.012 (.404)	−0.018 (.382)	0.004 (.873)
Issue voters: issue voter (N=2,728) vs. other motivation (N=2,308)			
AfD vote	0.021 (.003)	0.000 (.962)	0.020 (.063)
CDU vote	−0.014 (.032)	0.003 (.703)	−0.017 (.088)
AfD overall PCA	0.034 (.031)	−0.010 (.547)	0.044 (.057)
CDU overall PCA	−0.024 (.154)	−0.005 (.789)	−0.019 (.429)
Delegate ideal: delegate view (N=2,979) vs. trustee view (N=2,061)			
AfD vote	0.007 (.368)	0.014 (.068)	−0.008 (.425)
CDU vote	−0.002 (.730)	−0.013 (.115)	0.010 (.335)
AfD overall PCA	−0.001 (.961)	0.026 (.129)	−0.029 (.204)
CDU overall PCA	−0.009 (.548)	−0.024 (.208)	0.013 (.589)

Notes: Reduced-form coefficients of the signal (liberal direction) with HC1 p-values in parentheses, estimated separately within each subgroup with demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls. The interaction column reports the coefficient on signal × subgroup indicator in the full sample with the same controls. 2SLS counterparts are in the replication output. Own immigration attitude, the main heterogeneity dimension, is reported in Section 5.2.

The discipline here is family-level interpretation: we do not elevate an isolated subgroup coefficient merely because it crosses 5%. The East–West split is the only additional dimension with a large, coherent contrast that also maps naturally into the model's composition argument.

E Robustness to Attitude Grouping

The main analysis groups the eleven pre-treatment attitude values into liberal (0–4), moderate (5–6), and restrictive (7–10) categories chosen after data collection. We assess whether this grouping creates the heterogeneous pattern in two ways. First, we retain all eleven randomization strata and estimate a separate reduced-form signal effect within each exact attitude value. We then summarize the gradient with an interaction between the randomized signal and the respondent's continuous pre-treatment attitude, retaining attitude-stratum fixed effects. Second, we re-estimate the RF, 2SLS, and LLS effects after moving the restrictive-group threshold one point in either direction.

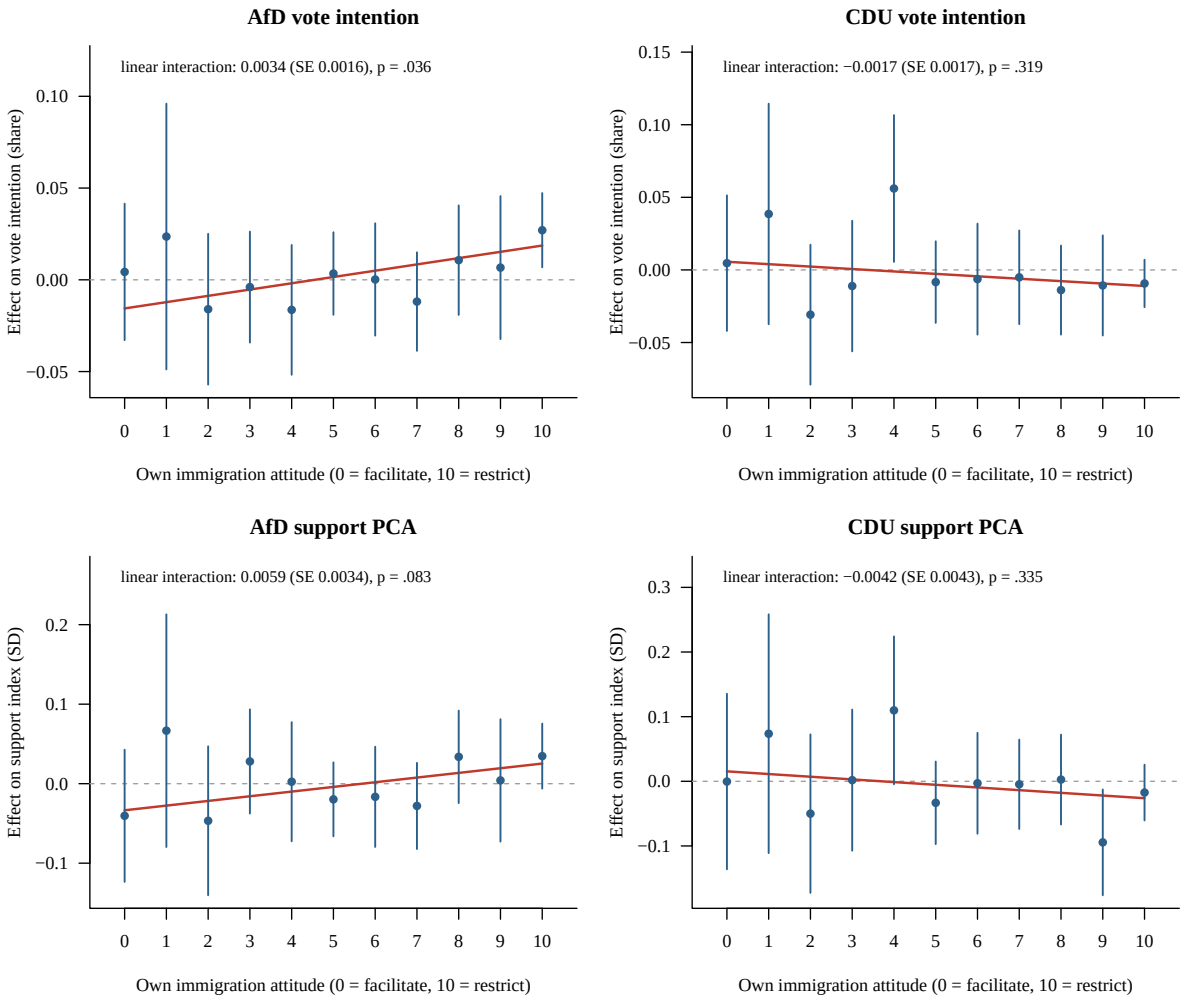


Figure E.2: Effects across all eleven pre-treatment attitude values.
Note: Points are reduced-form effects of a signal portraying the CDU as one unit more liberal, estimated separately within each exact value of the pre-treatment immigration-attitude scale; bars are 95% confidence intervals using HC1 standard errors. Red lines show fitted effects from a specification interacting the liberal-coded signal with the respondent's continuous attitude, centered at its sample mean. Every specification includes attitude-stratum fixed effects, demographic controls, and categorical CDU-prior indicators. Panel annotations report the interaction coefficient, its standard error, and its two-sided p-value. N = 5,040.

The AfD-vote gradient is positive and statistically significant: the effect of a one-unit more liberal signal increases by 0.34 percentage points for each one-point more restrictive attitude (p = .036). The AfD support-index gradient is also positive but less precise (0.0059 standard deviations per attitude point, p = .083). The CDU-vote and CDU-index gradients have the predicted negative signs but are not statistically distinguishable from zero. Although the individual-stratum estimates are necessarily noisier, they are consistent with a gradual AfD gradient rather than a discontinuity created by the boundaries of the three categories.

Table E.9: Effects under alternative definitions of restrictive voters

	Restrictive-voter definition		
	$x \geq 6$	$x \geq 7$ (paper grouping)	$x \geq 8$
Reduced form (per signal unit)			
AfD vote	0.016 (.017)	0.017 (.022)	0.021 (.008)
CDU vote	−0.009 (.156)	−0.009 (.168)	−0.009 (.187)
AfD overall PCA	0.025 (.074)	0.027 (.072)	0.035 (.030)
CDU overall PCA	−0.018 (.216)	−0.019 (.209)	−0.021 (.196)
N	3,529	3,165	2,604
2SLS (per posterior-belief unit)			
AfD vote	0.033 (.018)	0.035 (.022)	0.046 (.009)
CDU vote	−0.018 (.154)	−0.018 (.167)	−0.019 (.185)
AfD overall PCA	0.052 (.074)	0.056 (.071)	0.076 (.030)
CDU overall PCA	−0.036 (.212)	−0.040 (.205)	−0.046 (.191)
N	3,529	3,165	2,604
LLS, $h = .10$ (per posterior-belief unit)			
AfD vote	0.044 (.006)	0.047 (.004)	0.056 (.004)
CDU vote	−0.017 (.255)	−0.021 (.160)	−0.018 (.302)
AfD overall PCA	0.091 (.004)	0.101 (.009)	0.141 (.001)
CDU overall PCA	−0.069 (.024)	−0.089 (.011)	−0.079 (.038)
N ($\alpha > 0$)	1,827	1,622	1,288

Notes: Cells report coefficients with two-sided p-values in parentheses. RF and 2SLS use the full non-speeder sample within each alternative group, demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls, and HC1 inference. RF is measured per randomized-signal unit; 2SLS is measured per posterior-belief unit. LLS uses positive updaters, categorical CDU-prior controls, $h = .10$, group-specific normalized ranks, automatic trimming, and 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws; it is measured per posterior-belief unit. The $x \geq 7$ column reproduces the paper's main restrictive-group specification and inference.

Moving the threshold does not alter the conclusion. Defining the group as $x \geq 6$ yields AfD-vote effects of 1.6 percentage points in RF, 3.3 percentage points in 2SLS, and 4.4 percentage points in LLS. Defining it as $x \geq 8$ yields corresponding effects of 2.1, 4.6, and 5.6 percentage points. The AfD support index follows the same pattern. CDU vote effects remain negative across every threshold and estimator, while the CDU support-index decline remains statistically significant under LLS.

F LLS Specification and Local Identification

F.1 Main implementation

Table F.10: Main LLS heterogeneity specification

Choice	Main implementation
Estimator	Official `lls` 1.0.0 engine
Learning rate	(posterior − prior)/(signal − prior)
Sample	Non-speeders; prior ≠ signal; $\alpha > 0$
Rank	Dense normalized learning-rate rank, recomputed within each attitude-group estimation sample
Kernel and trimming	Epanechnikov; package automatic trimming
Bandwidth	$h = .10$
Local controls	Categorical CDU prior only
Inference	500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws; 1% absolute-tail trim for reported bootstrap SD

F.2 Numerical estimates underlying the main figure

Table F.11: Effects on party-support indexes by own immigration attitude

		AfD support PCA			CDU support PCA		
Group	Method	Effect	95% CI	p	Effect	95% CI	p
Liberal (0–4)	RF	−0.006	[−0.043, 0.031]	.735	0.036	[−0.013, 0.085]	.148
	2SLS	−0.013	[−0.087, 0.061]	.737	0.072	[−0.025, 0.169]	.147
	LLS	0.005	[−0.074, 0.077]	.906	0.021	[−0.076, 0.112]	.645
Moderate (5–6)	RF	−0.023	[−0.060, 0.014]	.215	−0.024	[−0.071, 0.024]	.335
	2SLS	−0.043	[−0.112, 0.026]	.225	−0.043	[−0.131, 0.045]	.336
	LLS	0.035	[−0.046, 0.099]	.343	0.079	[−0.052, 0.197]	.209
Conservative (7–10)	RF	0.027	[−0.002, 0.055]	.072	−0.019	[−0.048, 0.011]	.209
	2SLS	0.056	[−0.005, 0.117]	.071	−0.040	[−0.102, 0.022]	.205
	LLS	0.101	[0.027, 0.184]	.009	−0.089	[−0.156, −0.014]	.011

Notes: Numerical estimates underlying Figure 5. Positive coefficients mean that a more liberal CDU position or signal increases support for the named party. RF is per signal unit; 2SLS and LLS are per posterior-belief unit. RF and 2SLS use the full group samples, demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls, and HC1 inference. LLS uses positive updaters, categorical CDU-prior controls (Section 4.3), $h = .10$, group-specific normalized ranks, automatic trimming, and 500 Bayesian-bootstrap draws. LLS confidence intervals are percentile intervals; p-values use the Balla–Elliott 1% tail-trimmed bootstrap standard deviation.

Table F.12: Effects on vote intentions by own immigration attitude

		AfD vote intention			CDU vote intention		
Group	Method	Effect	95% CI	p	Effect	95% CI	p
Liberal (0–4)	RF	−0.008	[−0.025, 0.009]	.332	0.011	[−0.010, 0.032]	.313
	2SLS	−0.017	[−0.052, 0.018]	.348	0.022	[−0.020, 0.064]	.310
	LLS	0.007	[−0.027, 0.036]	.656	0.006	[−0.035, 0.041]	.760
Moderate (5–6)	RF	−0.001	[−0.018, 0.017]	.951	−0.007	[−0.030, 0.015]	.510
	2SLS	−0.001	[−0.033, 0.031]	.951	−0.014	[−0.054, 0.027]	.510
	LLS	0.029	[−0.011, 0.060]	.088	0.016	[−0.031, 0.063]	.488
Conservative (7–10)	RF	0.017	[0.002, 0.031]	.022	−0.009	[−0.021, 0.004]	.168
	2SLS	0.035	[0.005, 0.065]	.022	−0.018	[−0.044, 0.008]	.167
	LLS	0.047	[0.016, 0.082]	.004	−0.021	[−0.054, 0.007]	.160

Notes: Numerical estimates underlying Figure 4. Effects in vote shares (0.047 = 4.7 percentage points). Same samples, controls, estimators, units, and inference conventions as Table F.11.

F.3 Why the subgroup control vector is parsimonious

Table F.13: Local identification diagnostic across 261 subgroup evaluation windows

Control design	Columns	Posterior unidentified	Non-positive residual df
Historical full vector	23	33	31
Categorical CDU prior only	12	5	0

The smallest local windows contain 6 observations among liberals, 5 among moderates, and 11 among respondents with restrictive preferences under the historical signed-rank diagnostic. A specification that changes which windows identify the posterior coefficient because it has more regressors than local observations is not a neutral precision improvement. The parsimonious design keeps the causally necessary prior control and avoids this failure.

F.4 Updater and rank variants

Table F.14: Restrictive-group results under alternative updater and rank rules

Negative updaters	Rank sample	AfD overall	CDU overall	AfD behavioral	CDU behavioral
Excluded	Within group (main)	0.101	−0.089	0.089	−0.081
Excluded	Global	0.084	−0.082	0.066	−0.080
Included	Within group	0.095	−0.076	0.093	−0.076
Included	Global	0.080	−0.070	0.074	−0.075

The restrictive-group all-outcome signs and magnitudes persist in every row. The AfD behavioral p-value is more sensitive to the rank construction, so we emphasize the component-level margins that remain stable across specifications.

F.5 Pre-registered sample restrictions

Table F.15: Pre-registered sample restrictions

	Full	Attention check	Credible	Incl. speeders
Pooled, 2SLS				
AfD vote	0.021 (.047)	0.022 (.037)	0.025 (.034)	0.023 (.037)
CDU vote	−0.013 (.206)	−0.011 (.269)	−0.019 (.116)	−0.013 (.217)
AfD overall PCA	0.026 (.254)	0.028 (.207)	0.036 (.150)	0.024 (.310)
CDU overall PCA	−0.029 (.225)	−0.023 (.344)	−0.031 (.270)	−0.031 (.210)
N	5,040	4,640	3,655	5,127
Conservative (7–10), 2SLS				
AfD vote	0.035 (.022)	0.035 (.019)	0.044 (.010)	0.036 (.020)
CDU vote	−0.018 (.167)	−0.014 (.271)	−0.038 (.016)	−0.017 (.199)
AfD overall PCA	0.056 (.071)	0.055 (.072)	0.080 (.021)	0.053 (.092)
CDU overall PCA	−0.040 (.205)	−0.034 (.274)	−0.059 (.111)	−0.037 (.247)
N	3,165	2,975	2,199	3,215
Conservative (7–10), LLS (h = .10, CDU-prior control)				
AfD vote	—	0.038 (.023)	0.041 (.027)	—
CDU vote	—	−0.017 (.272)	−0.026 (.163)	—
AfD overall PCA	—	0.097 (.008)	0.095 (.010)	—
CDU overall PCA	—	−0.076 (.029)	−0.090 (.035)	—

Notes: 2SLS coefficients of the CDU posterior (liberal direction) with HC1 p-values in parentheses; demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls. Column samples: full non-speeders; respondents passing the second attention check; respondents rating the information at least "rather credible"; all completes including the 87 speeders. The LLS panel re-estimates the restrictive-group cells under the main estimator (h = .10, categorical CDU-prior control, group-specific normalized ranks, 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws) in the two pre-registered restricted samples.

G Behavioral PCA Results

The behavioral PCA is constructed separately for each party from newsletter-link clicks, the real-stakes donation measure, and campaign-ad allocations. Each component is signed so that higher values indicate greater party support; the first component is then standardized in the non-speeder sample. These outcomes are pre-registered, but the behavioral-only PCA is a transparent summary constructed for this revision and is therefore secondary to the pre-registered all-outcome PCA.

Table G.16: Behavioral PCA effects by own immigration attitude

		AfD behavioral PCA			CDU behavioral PCA		
Group	Method	Effect	95% CI	p	Effect	95% CI	p
Liberal (0–4)	RF	−0.009	[−0.048, 0.030]	.648	0.009	[−0.039, 0.058]	.713
	2SLS	−0.018	[−0.096, 0.060]	.651	0.018	[−0.078, 0.115]	.713
	LLS	−0.024	[−0.115, 0.079]	.612	0.015	[−0.073, 0.109]	.750
Moderate (5–6)	RF	−0.030	[−0.068, 0.008]	.117	−0.027	[−0.074, 0.020]	.256
	2SLS	−0.056	[−0.127, 0.016]	.126	−0.049	[−0.135, 0.036]	.258
	LLS	0.002	[−0.078, 0.077]	.960	0.138	[−0.010, 0.291]	.080
Conservative (7–10)	RF	0.006	[−0.025, 0.036]	.715	−0.011	[−0.042, 0.020]	.478
	2SLS	0.012	[−0.052, 0.076]	.714	−0.024	[−0.089, 0.042]	.476
	LLS	0.089	[0.019, 0.159]	.015	−0.081	[−0.158, −0.009]	.032

Notes: Same controls, samples, estimators, units, and inference conventions as Table F.11. The positive moderate CDU LLS estimate is not stable across bandwidths and is not interpreted as a finding. The restrictive-group behavioral coefficients have the predicted signs under all three estimators, with the LLS estimates reaching statistical significance.

Table G.17: Behavioral components among respondents with restrictive preferences, LLS across bandwidths

	$h = .05$		$h = .075$		$h = .10$		$h = .125$		$h = .15$	
Outcome	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p
AfD newsletter	0.078	.020	0.085	.033	0.085	.035	0.058	.138	0.046	.243
AfD campaign	0.067	.109	0.075	.043	0.073	.053	0.038	.300	0.032	.366
AfD donation	0.046	.282	0.040	.322	0.038	.334	−0.001	.985	−0.009	.804
CDU newsletter	−0.041	.435	−0.010	.814	−0.009	.834	−0.030	.389	−0.032	.330
CDU campaign	−0.168	< .001	−0.103	.005	−0.096	.014	−0.092	.004	−0.090	.003
CDU donation	−0.125	.004	−0.050	.199	−0.046	.230	−0.053	.132	−0.059	.080

Notes: LLS estimates among restrictive positive updaters (N = 1,622); each component standardized in the non-speeder sample and signed so that higher values indicate greater support. Categorical CDU-prior controls, group-specific normalized ranks, automatic trimming, 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws per cell; p-values use the 1% tail-trimmed bootstrap standard deviation. The CDU campaign-material effect is significant at every bandwidth; the AfD newsletter effect only at $h \leq .10$; the donation margins only in the CDU's narrowest-bandwidth cell. In the pooled positive-updater sample at $h = .10$ under the main pooled controls, the AfD newsletter effect is 0.063 ($p = .018$) and the CDU campaign effect −0.045 ($p = .098$); under categorical-CDU-prior-only controls the corresponding estimates are 0.055 ($p = .031$) and −0.060 ($p = .019$); all other pooled components are null. All six components are null in RF and 2SLS in the restrictive and pooled samples.

G.1 Thermometers and abstention

Table G.18: Pre-registered thermometer and abstention outcomes

		Pooled	Liberal	Moderate	Conservative
AfD thermometer (SD)	RF	0.025 (.037)	0.016 (.464)	−0.024 (.249)	0.040 (.007)
	2SLS	0.049 (.037)	0.031 (.460)	−0.044 (.258)	0.085 (.007)
CDU thermometer (SD)	RF	−0.006 (.636)	0.059 (.023)	−0.006 (.792)	−0.016 (.264)
	2SLS	−0.011 (.635)	0.116 (.025)	−0.012 (.792)	−0.034 (.259)
Abstention (SD)	RF	0.001 (.914)	0.023 (.453)	−0.004 (.892)	−0.005 (.722)
	2SLS	0.003 (.914)	0.046 (.457)	−0.007 (.892)	−0.011 (.723)
N		5,040	823	1,052	3,165

Notes: Feeling thermometers and stated abstention likelihood, standardized in the non-speeder sample. RF coefficients of the signal and 2SLS coefficients of the instrumented CDU posterior (liberal direction), HC1 p-values in parentheses; demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls.

H Bandwidth Robustness

Table H.19: Bandwidth sensitivity among respondents with restrictive preferences

	AfD overall		CDU overall		AfD behavioral		CDU behavioral	
h	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p
.050	0.105	.008	−0.170	< .001	0.087	.024	−0.176	< .001
.075	0.104	.003	−0.094	.009	0.091	.019	−0.088	.026
.100	0.101	.009	−0.089	.011	0.089	.015	−0.081	.032
.125	0.065	.073	−0.087	.007	0.041	.301	−0.091	.008
.150	0.057	.094	−0.088	.003	0.029	.429	−0.095	.004

Notes: Coefficients and two-sided paper-style bootstrap p-values; 500 draws at $h = .075$–.15 and 1,000 at $h = .05$. At $h = .05$, the values coincide with $h = .025$ because the discrete normalized-rank support selects the same local neighborhoods.

I Pooled Posterior Robustness

Table I.20: Pooled posterior effects across outcome indexes and controls

Outcome	Controls	Method	Effect	p
AfD overall	CDU prior + demographics (main)	RF	0.013	.256
		2SLS	0.026	.254
		LLS	0.046	.099
	CDU prior only	RF	0.014	.247
		2SLS	0.027	.246
		LLS	0.037	.218
	CDU and AfD priors + demographics	RF	0.010	.354
		2SLS	0.021	.353
		LLS	0.047	.117
CDU overall	CDU prior + demographics (main)	RF	−0.015	.227
		2SLS	−0.029	.225
		LLS	−0.052	.065
	CDU prior only	RF	−0.015	.228
		2SLS	−0.030	.226
		LLS	−0.064	.022
	CDU and AfD priors + demographics	RF	−0.015	.215
		2SLS	−0.030	.213
		LLS	−0.047	.083
AfD behavioral	CDU prior + demographics (main)	RF	−0.003	.783
		2SLS	−0.006	.783
		LLS	0.026	.364
	CDU prior only	RF	−0.003	.815
		2SLS	−0.006	.815
		LLS	0.017	.576
	CDU and AfD priors + demographics	RF	−0.005	.660
		2SLS	−0.010	.661
		LLS	0.027	.331
CDU behavioral	CDU prior + demographics (main)	RF	−0.014	.244
		2SLS	−0.028	.243
		LLS	−0.040	.165
	CDU prior only	RF	−0.014	.244
		2SLS	−0.029	.242
		LLS	−0.054	.055
	CDU and AfD priors + demographics	RF	−0.014	.243
		2SLS	−0.029	.241
		LLS	−0.037	.186

Notes: RF and 2SLS use the full non-speeder sample with the listed pre-treatment controls and HC1 inference. LLS uses the corresponding controls in the positive-updater sample and bootstrap inference. RF is per signal unit; 2SLS and LLS are per posterior-belief unit.

The pooled sample contains 2,654 positive updaters, and 40 of 42 normalized-rank support points remain effective after automatic trimming. Adding demographics, or additionally the

AfD prior, does not create the local rank-deficiency problem found in the attitude subgroups. The AfD-prior rows show that a second party prior, which the identification argument does not require, moves no estimate by more than 0.005 standard deviations. The CDU-prior-only rows hold the controls fixed relative to the attitude-group analysis; they move the pooled LLS indexes by up to 0.014 standard deviations, toward larger CDU effects (the CDU index reaches −0.064, $p = .022$), so the main specification is the conservative choice among the three.

I.1 The pre-registered representation-gap estimand

Table I.21: The pre-registered representation-gap estimand

	2SLS coef. (p)	LLS (positive gap-updaters) coef. (p)	N
AfD vote	0.041 (.039)	0.088 (< .001)	955
CDU vote	−0.025 (.205)	−0.018 (.014)	955
AfD overall PCA	0.050 (.240)	0.195 (< .001)	955
CDU overall PCA	−0.057 (.223)	−0.056 (.001)	955
AfD thermometer (SD)	0.095 (.030)	—	—
CDU thermometer (SD)	−0.022 (.634)	—	—
Abstention (SD)	0.005 (.914)	—	—
First-stage F	96.6	—	
N (2SLS)	5,040		

Notes: The pre-analysis plan's instrumented specification: the perceived representation gap (distance between own attitude and the closest non-AfD party), instrumented by the signal, with demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls, HC1 inference. LLS: positive gap-updaters, gap learning rates as the running variable, $h = .10$, sample-normalized ranks, 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws, demographic and categorical CDU-prior controls; index and behavioral cells from the pooled control-set grid, vote cells estimated for this table. Thermometer and abstention rows have no LLS counterpart in the pre-analysis plan's grid.

J Pre-Treatment Placebo Tests

Table J.22: Posterior LLS placebo audit

	No CDU-prior control		Prior-controlled (production)	
Pre-treatment outcome	Effect	95% CI	Effect	95% CI
Own immigration attitude (SD)	0.012	[−0.014, 0.041]	−0.044	[−0.110, 0.023]
Prior AfD position belief (SD)	0.051	[0.024, 0.080]	0.052	[−0.012, 0.120]

Notes: Main LLS (pooled positive updaters, $N = 2{,}654$; package normalized ranks, $h = .10$, 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws) applied to standardized pre-treatment outcomes, with and without the categorical CDU-prior control. The AfD prior belief is liberal-coded.

The uncontrolled implementation's significant coefficient on the pre-treatment AfD-position belief cannot be causal, because the outcome precedes treatment. With the categorical CDU prior included, neither placebo is statistically distinguishable from zero. This audit independently corroborates the theoretical requirement to condition on the prior.

K Follow-Up Study

We conducted an obfuscated follow-up approximately one week after each participant completed the main survey. The same survey firm distributed it, but the visual layout, tone, and wording were changed to make the connection difficult to detect. The follow-up contained only vote intentions and feeling thermometers, standard questions participants could plausibly encounter in an unrelated political survey. The thermometer used a 0–100 numerical response rather than the main survey's 11 horizontally arranged options. All follow-up data collection ended on February 22, 2025, the day before the election.

Despite repeated invitations and a higher implied hourly payment than in the main survey, 2,182 of the 5,040 main-study participants provided at least one follow-up outcome, a recontact rate of 43.3%. Attrition is descriptively selective: follow-up respondents are younger and more likely to live in West Germany. It is not detectably related to randomized assignment ($p = .63$), preserving the internal treatment comparison under the observed assignment process, and inverse-probability weighting on observables produces similar point estimates. Selection on unobserved political engagement remains possible, so the follow-up is secondary to the full-sample main experiment.

Table K.23: Follow-up evidence under the main specification

Outcome	Effect	CI / inference	Conclusion
AfD vote intention, LLS	0.011	[−0.022, 0.043]	directionally positive, not significant
CDU vote intention, LLS	−0.029	[−0.062, 0.008]	directionally negative, not significant (p = .104)
Other AfD and CDU outcomes, LLS	—	all $p > .23$	no significant persistence evidence
Reduced form and 2SLS	—	all $p > .17$	no significant persistence evidence (AfD vote 2SLS +0.001, p = .924)
Bandwidths .075–.20	—	all insignificant	pattern unchanged across the grid
Bandwidth .05	—	AfD +0.045, CDU −0.038, both $p < .04$	local windows of ∼58 observations against ∼20 regressors; not interpreted
Follow-up participation by signal arms	—	joint p = .63	no differential attrition

Notes: LLS estimated on the 1,169 positive updaters among the 1,933 follow-up respondents with defined learning rates (prior ≠ signal) and complete main-wave covariates; follow-up-sample normalized ranks, h = .10 unless stated, categorical CDU-prior and demographic controls, 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws. Results are unchanged with CDU-prior-only controls or with added categorical AfD-prior indicators. RF and 2SLS use all 2,182 follow-up respondents.

Table K.24: Follow-up effects by attitude group

	Liberal (0–4)		Moderate (5–6)		Conservative (7–10)	
Follow-up outcome	Effect	p	Effect	p	Effect	p
AfD vote intention	0.022	.276	0.006	.791	−0.006	.780
AfD thermometer	0.050	.389	−0.059	.244	0.054	.258
CDU vote intention	0.028	.255	−0.013	.665	−0.029	.191
CDU thermometer	−0.024	.784	0.010	.874	0.005	.926
Abstention	−0.028	.707	−0.206	< .001	−0.014	.649

Notes: Main LLS within each attitude group of the follow-up sample: positive updaters (N = 202 liberal, 267 moderate, 700 restrictive), group-specific normalized ranks, h = .10, categorical CDU-prior controls, 500 seeded Bayesian-bootstrap draws; p-values use the 1% tail-trimmed bootstrap standard deviation. Vote effects in shares; thermometers and abstention in standard deviations. The restrictive-group AfD-vote and AfD-index cells remain insignificant at every bandwidth in .075–.15 and with demographic controls added; the design-based restrictive-group estimates are likewise null (AfD vote 2SLS +0.010, p = .66, N = 1,325). The moderate abstention cell rests on local windows of roughly 27 observations and is contradicted by the design-based estimate (+0.027, p = .66) and by the null pooled abstention results in both waves; because the cell is inconsistent across waves and adjacent bins, we do not interpret it.

Table K.25: Follow-up attrition and weighting

Fact	Interpretation
2,182 of 5,040 respondents provide an outcome	43.3% recontact; roughly 57% attrition.
Follow-up respondents are younger and more Western	Follow-up is not descriptively representative of the main sample.
No signal-related attrition ($p = .63$)	Internal treatment comparisons are not detectably selected by assignment.
Inverse-probability weighting on observables	Point estimates are similar, but selection on unobserved political engagement cannot be ruled out.

L Outcome Construction and Survey Items

L.1 Outcome construction

The AfD and CDU all-outcome PCA indexes are pre-registered. For each party they combine vote intention, feeling thermometer, newsletter-link click, donation willingness, and campaign-ad allocation after signing every component so that higher values indicate greater support. Components are standardized, the first principal component is extracted, and the resulting score is standardized again. Turnout is excluded from the party indexes.

Table L.26: Outcome families

Family	Measure	Scale and interpretation
Stated electoral support	Vote intention; feeling thermometer	Party choice indicator and standardized 0–100/11-point thermometer.
Information seeking	Newsletter-link click	Binary indication of opening the party subscription page; click-through is observed, not completed subscription.
Costly support	Donation staircase	Minimum compensation required to permit a real €5 donation on the respondent's behalf, reverse-signed for support.
Campaign support	Allocation of future campaign ads	Number of 1,000 future participants assigned to receive each party's official campaign ad.
Felt representation	"How well does the CDU represent people like you?"	1–7 scale.

The newsletter outcome records whether participants open a party's subscription page, not whether they complete a subscription. The donation task asks for the minimum additional compensation required to permit a real €5 donation to the CDU or AfD on the participant's behalf. Following Falk et al. (2018), an adaptive staircase of four or five binary choices elicits this amount. Higher required compensation indicates lower party support and is reverse-signed before entering the PCA. For campaign allocations, participants are truthfully told that a future study will show official party advertisements to 1,000 German adults and that a randomly selected participant's allocation will determine how many future respondents see each party's advertisement.

L.2 Core question and information treatment

The core pre-treatment question is: *"What is your personal opinion on the topic of immigration opportunities? Please use the following scale from 0 to 10. A value of 0 means that, in your opinion, immigration opportunities should be strongly facilitated. A value of 10 means that, in your opinion, immigration opportunities should be strongly restricted. You can use the values*

between 0 and 10 to grade your opinion." Before treatment, respondents locate every major party on the same scale.

The information screen introduces the candidate data as follows: *"Scientists have long been researching how to measure the positions of political parties. As recent studies have shown, one valid method is to evaluate the responses of parties' candidates in an anonymous survey. We used this method to measure the immigration stance of German parties. For this purpose, we analyzed the answers of some Bundestag candidates to the same question we just asked you. The currently available data are for candidates to the 2021 Bundestag election, so we have no data for Sarah Wagenknecht's Alliance yet. We will provide you with information on the responses of 503 candidates. These are broken down by party as follows: CDU/CSU, 11; AfD, 58; SPD, 65; Greens, 131; FDP, 117; Left, 121."* All participants receive the same positions for every party except the CDU, whose displayed median varies randomly across 4, 5, 6, and 7. Post-treatment, respondents again locate the parties, report felt representation and coalition expectations, and complete the outcome blocks.